

and France came to a head in 1870 with France's humiliating defeat by Germany in the Franco-Prussian war, which led to the annexation of most of the French provinces of Alsace and Lorraine.

In Eastern Europe, the Austro-Hungarian and Russian empires had a long-standing dispute over which of them had the strongest claim to power in the Balkans. Both depended on the area for access to the Mediterranean, and each eyed the movements of the other with intense suspicion.

Each state needed allies, and in 1882 Austria-Hungary, Germany, and Italy signed a Triple Alliance promising to give each other military support in case of war. Then, in the 1890s, Russia and France signed an agreement to protect one another in the event of a war against Germany. By the turn of the century, Kaiser Wilhelm II's provocative nationalistic speeches and naval expansion pushed Britain into closer ties with France. In 1904, Britain and France agreed an *entente cordiale*, or friendly alliance, which was broadened into a triple entente, embracing Russia, in 1907. The triple entente would become known as the Allied Powers. The atmosphere generated by this international jostling led to an increase in military spending by European governments and the expansion of armies and navies.

War erupts

A spark was all that was needed to ignite the flame of enmity between these two alliances. It came on June 28, 1914, when a Bosnian Serb assassinated Archduke Franz Ferdinand, heir to the Hapsburg throne, in Sarajevo. The Austrians suspected Serbia, their principal enemy in the Balkans, of the attack. After securing support from its ally Germany, Austria-Hungary presented Serbia with an ultimatum on July 23, demanding that the Serbs stop all anti-Austria-Hungary activities. Serbia accepted most of the demands, but Austria-Hungary declared war on Serbia on July 28. Britain called for international mediation, but the crisis quickly escalated into European war. When Russia mobilized against Austria-Hungary, Germany

European powers are bound together in a **complex web of alliances.**

A European arms race leads to **larger armies** and more **destructive weapons.**

War breaks out, eventually drawing in all the major powers and causing **death on a scale previously unimaginable.**

The **relative equality of the armies** means that neither side can score a decisive victory.

The fighting on the Western Front becomes a bitter stalemate despite the enormous cost of battles like Passchendaele.

With both sides exhausted, **US entry into the war** on the side of the Allies facilitates a **breakthrough in the conflict.**

declared war on Russia on August 1, and on France two days later. Britain joined the war on August 4, after the Germans invaded neutral Belgium. The British Expeditionary Force (BEF), a small professional troop led by Sir Douglas Haig, had arrived in France by August 22. It was deployed near the Franco-Belgian border, in line with pre-war military plans agreed with the French government.

Germany had to fight a war on two fronts. On the Western Front, in the first weeks of the conflict, the Germans invaded Belgium and France, but their advance was halted by the French and British at the Battle of the Marne. By the end of fall, the two sides had reached a stalemate. Meanwhile, on the Eastern Front, the fighting remained fluid. Germany dominated, scoring a great victory against the Russians at »